

1. Feel a little bit closer to home at the Four Seasons Resort Mauritius at Anahita, where the cuisine has an Indian influence

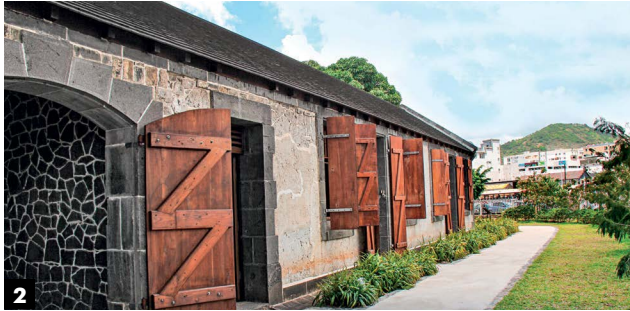
2. One of the most poignant reminders of the island's history Aapravasi Ghat, which once functioned as the immigration depot for Indian labourers

3. The Blue Penny Museum in Port Louis houses not one but two of the rarest stamps issued in 1847

4. Another must-visit is Le Morne Brabant, a UNESCO World Heritage Site



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I saw these was when I visited my mother's village in Bihar. Another connection to home.

Before Mauritius became known as a tourist hotspot for its azure water and golden beaches, sugar was the primary economic driver. The first sugarcane plant was brought to the island by the Dutch who, incidentally, were also the first set-

tlers. They also brought domestic animals and deer, probably leading to the extinction of the dodo that was native to Mauritius. Of course, these big, flightless birds were also culled for their meat. "The Dutch just ate them all," says Babulal. The dodo continues to be the island nation's biggest mascot. You see it on everything

from t-shirts to emblems to even the immigration stamp!

Post the Dutch, it was under the French rule, which lasted over a century, that the history of Mauritius was shaped by sugar. The French established several sugar factories and brought African slaves to work in the sugarcane fields.